

CODEALPHA • CYBER SECURITY INTERNSHIP

Phishing Awareness Training

Recognizing, resisting, and reporting social-engineering attacks

Task 2 • Prepared as part of the CodeAlpha Cyber Security Internship



What we'll cover

01

What Is Phishing?

Definition and the psychology behind the attack



02

Types of Attacks

Email, spear phishing, whaling, smishing, vishing, clone phishing



03

Anatomy of an Attack

Deconstructing a real-looking phishing email



04

Impact & Statistics

Why phishing remains the #1 breach vector



05

Spotting Red Flags

A practical checklist you can use today



06

Response & Prevention

What to do when you spot one, and how to stay protected





01

What Is Phishing?

A social-engineering attack that impersonates a trusted source to steal data, credentials, or money.

DEFINITION

Phishing is a fraudulent attempt to obtain sensitive information — usernames, passwords, card numbers — by disguising as a trustworthy entity in an email, message, or website.

WHY IT WORKS — THE PSYCHOLOGY



Urgency

Fake deadlines pressure quick, unchecked action



Authority

Impersonates a boss, bank, or government body



Fear

Threatens account suspension or legal trouble



Curiosity

Irresistible subject lines and fake attachments

Six faces of phishing



Email Phishing

Mass fraudulent emails impersonating banks, vendors, or services, sent to thousands of targets at once.



Spear Phishing

Highly targeted messages, personalized with the victim's name, role, or recent activity for credibility.



Whaling

Spear phishing aimed at executives or senior staff — often impersonating a CEO to authorize payments.



Smishing

Phishing delivered via SMS text message, usually with a shortened malicious link.



Vishing

Voice-call phishing — a caller impersonates IT support, a bank, or law enforcement.

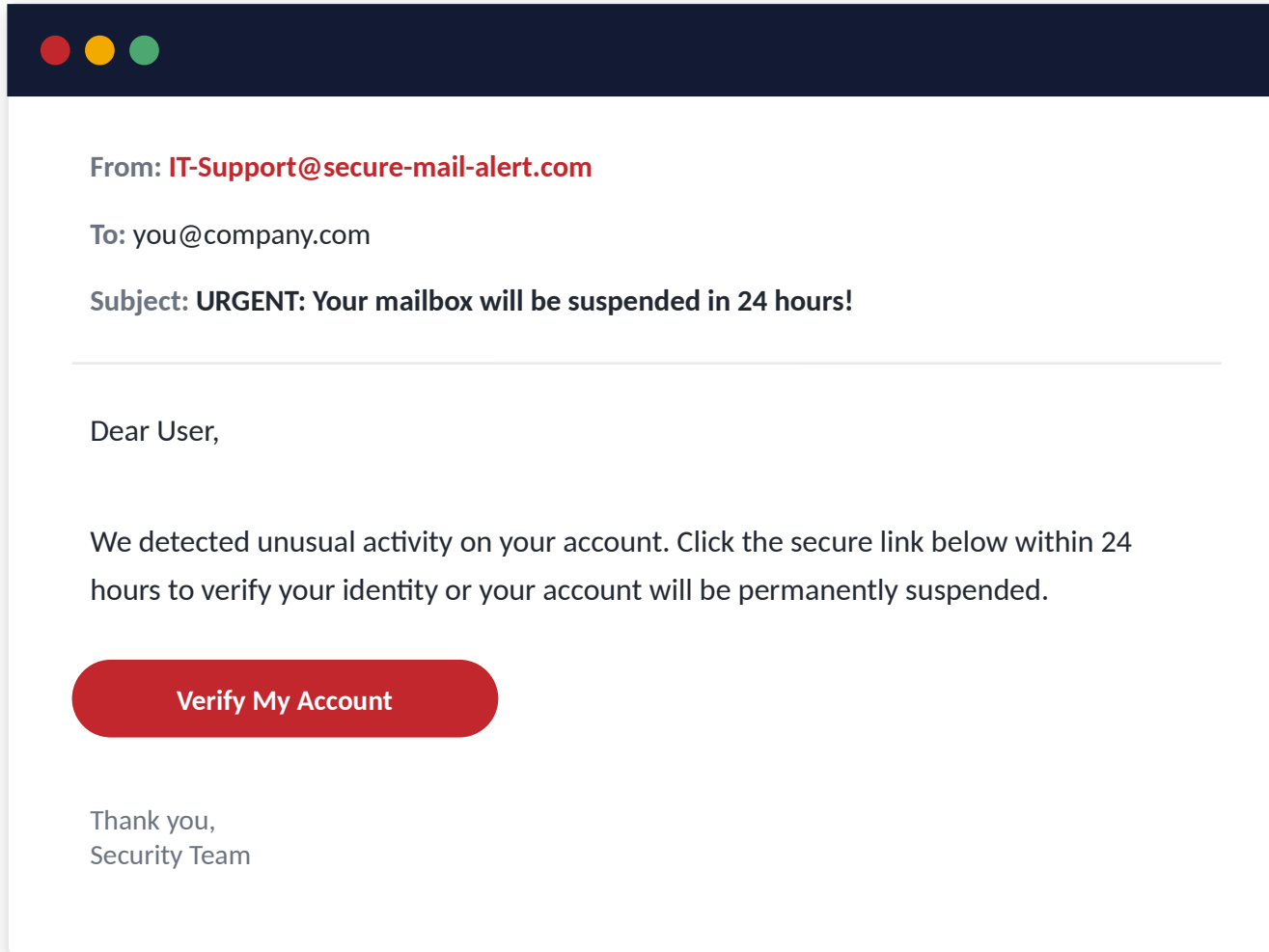


Clone Phishing

A legitimate, previously delivered email is copied and resent with links swapped for malicious ones.

Deconstructing a phishing email

A fictional, illustrative example — not a real organization



RED FLAGS

- 1 Sender domain**
Looks official but isn't the real company domain
- 2 Manufactured urgency**
"24 hours" pressures you to act without thinking
- 3 Generic greeting**
"Dear User" instead of your actual name
- 4 Suspicious CTA button**
Hides the real destination URL on hover

IMPACT & STATISTICS

Why phishing still wins

Illustrative figures based on widely cited industry security reports



90%+

of successful data breaches start
with a phishing email



#1

phishing remains the most
common cyberattack vector year
over year



~1 in 4

employees will click a simulated
phishing link if untrained



Minutes

is often all it takes from click to
compromised credentials

Sources: annual industry breach & phishing simulation reports (e.g., Verizon DBIR, Proofpoint). Figures are approximate and for awareness purposes.

The 8-point phishing checklist



Check the real sender address

Not just the display name — hover or tap to reveal the full email domain.



Question urgent deadlines

Legitimate organizations rarely demand action "within 24 hours".



Watch for generic greetings

"Dear Customer" instead of your actual name is a common tell.



Never provide sensitive data via email

Banks and IT never ask for full passwords or card PINs by email.



Hover before you click

Preview the actual destination URL; look for misspelled or unusual domains.



Be wary of unexpected attachments

Especially .zip, .exe, or macro-enabled Office files.



Look for spelling & grammar errors

Subtle typos and awkward phrasing often slip through.



Verify through an official channel

Contact the organization directly using a known, trusted number or site.

RESPONSE PLAN

If you suspect a phishing attempt



Don't Click

Avoid clicking links, opening attachments, or replying to the sender.



Pause & Inspect

Check the sender domain, links, and tone against the red-flag checklist.



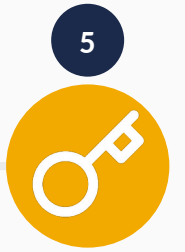
Report It

Use your organization's "Report Phishing" button or forward it to IT/Security.



Delete the Message

Once reported, remove it from your inbox to prevent accidental clicks later.



Reset Credentials

If you already clicked or entered details, change your password immediately.



Golden rule: when in doubt, don't click — verify through a separate, trusted channel first.

Best practices for staying protected



Enable Multi-Factor Authentication

Adds a second layer of defense even if a password is stolen.



Use a Password Manager

Generates & stores unique, strong passwords for every account.



Keep Software Updated

Patches close the vulnerabilities phishing payloads try to exploit.



Complete Security Awareness Training

Regular training keeps red flags top of mind for every employee.



Use Email Filtering & Anti-Phishing Tools

Automated filters catch a large share of attempts before the inbox.



Build a "Report, Don't Ignore" Culture

Make reporting fast and blame-free so real threats surface quickly.

Key takeaways



Phishing exploits trust and urgency, not just technology



Always verify the sender and the link before you act



MFA and password managers blunt the impact of stolen credentials



Legitimate organizations never demand passwords or PINs by email



Reporting a suspicious message protects the whole organization



Stay alert. Stay verified.

Thank you for completing Phishing Awareness Training



CodeAlpha Cyber Security Internship — Task 2

Questions? Reach out to your mentor or security team.